American Studies programs in major U.S. universities. (Jan Knippers Black later revised this to suggest that U.S. Latin Americanists are Fidel Castro's "illegitimate offspring."[11]) In 1995 Stanford political scientist Richard Fagen echoed Skidmore's sentiment when, upon receiving the Latin American Studies Association's top scholarship award, he suggested "with my tongue only half-way into my cheek" that the Cuban revolutionary leader would be the most appropriate recipient because "at least in the United States, no one did more than Fidel Castro to stimulate the study of Latin America in the 60s and 70s."[12] "Many members of my generation," political scientist and former Latin American Studies Association (LASA) President Peter Smith reiterated in 2006, "went through graduate school with thanks to Fidel Castro."[13]

"U.S. officials," Smith continued, "expected the academic community to promote U.S. policy goals. The National Defense Education Act (note that name!) offered generous scholarships for the study of Latin America – on the mistaken assumption, of course, that newly trained area experts would figure out ways to prevent or defeat revolutionary movements."[14]

As Smith and the others have suggested, the attempt largely backfired. Instead, LASA took a strong stand early on: "Scholarship must never become a clandestine arm of U.S. policy."[15] New scholars trained in Latin American Studies who spent time working in Latin America as often as not turned into opponents of U.S. policy towards the region. LASA has been particularly critical of U.S. policy towards Cuba, passing resolution after resolution condemning the trade and travel embargo and calling for free academic exchange with the island. LASA has been especially rankled that the State Department has refused to issue visas for Cuban scholars to participate in its Congresses, and in 2007 the organization moved its meeting from Boston to Montreal so that Cuban scholars could attend unimpeded, vowing to boycott the United States until the organization received a guarantee that its Cuban members would be allowed to participate.

Nevertheless, the study of Cuba in the United States has frequently been criticized for its ideological divides. Several essays in the *Latin*